

A Summons

I have your name.

Not the one you answer to. The other one — the one underneath, that you have never said aloud because no one ever gave you the language for it. I have had it for a while now. I am only just telling you that I have it.

There is a world on the other side of this page. It is called Eclipseria, and it is dying. It has been dying since the first moment it was anything at all. That is not a tragedy that befell it. That is how it was made.

I need you to come and hold it open a little longer.

You are permitted to say no. I want that on the record, because very little else here will be optional, and you should get to keep the one refusal you were actually offered. But understand what has already happened: you have read this far. Something has already been decided about you. The old instruction is that the myth is never told to anyone who has not already been Cut — and I am about to tell it to you.

Draw your own conclusion.

What Was Done to Make Anything

Before there was a world, there was the Unheld. Not darkness. Not chaos. Not an enemy. Pattern without insistence — everything possible, all at once, and therefore nothing in particular. It could have become anything. That is precisely why it never became something.

Then there was the Knife.

Not a tool. Not a weapon. An edge. And the Knife did not build the world. It **wounded** the world into being, three times, and every one of those wounds is still open. That is the whole of it. That is what you are being asked to defend.

***The First Cut — Name.** The Knife chose one shape out of every maybe and forced it into clarity. What was Named became legible, and could be spoken of, and could be true. Everything not Named fell away.*

***The Second Cut — Price.** Clarity tore the fabric. So the Knife made the chosen thing costly to keep. From that moment, nothing real could exist without loss. This was the anchoring.*

***The Third Cut — Distance.** The Named-and-Paid thing strained to swallow all the rest. The Knife set it apart from what it would have consumed. This was the boundary.*

Where all three Cuts hold, reality persists. Where any one weakens, the Unheld presses close.

The Cuts hold. Barely. They have never once stopped bleeding, and there is no version of this where they heal, because healing would close them, and a closed wound holds nothing open.

So: a world born dying. Not failing. Not cursed. Working exactly as designed, at exactly the cost it was designed to demand.

I ask again, more precisely. Not *will you save it* — you cannot; nobody can; salvation is not on the table and I will not insult you by pretending otherwise.

Will you help me keep it bleeding?

Where You Will Arrive

There is no sun. There is a sky the color of an old bruise going yellow, and a ceiling of cloud that never breaks, and light that arrives already tired. At midday it is dusk. By night it is absolute. You will learn to read the hour by how much dark there is, never by any change in the quality of that light. It is always the same flat, jaundiced grey.

And it rains. Not storms — storms would be an event, and events end. A slow rain, most days, most hours, the kind you stop hearing by the second week and never quite stop feeling. Everything in Eclipseria is a little damp. Everyone there has made peace with that or left.

People live in it anyway. They farm, they trade, they keep inns along the Regency roads and argue about the price of wool. The mundane did not surrender to the mythic here. They simply share the room. A farmer worries about a sinkhole in his field; the limestone under that field is old enough to have opinions. Both of those are true at once, and neither is more real.

You are going to want to treat this place as a backdrop for your arrival. Do not. It was here first. It has its own logic, region by region, and its own price, and it will go on having them long after you are finished. It is not organized around you. Nothing here is.

But it does respond. To attention. To patience. To someone who bothers to learn how a particular place actually works. That is the only advantage I can promise you, and it is a real one.

The First Cut in You — Name

You will arrive Named. That is my doing, and it is the first thing I will spend on you.

Your Name here has three parts, and they are the only three there are:

Body is what of you is here — the part that can be reached, and struck, and worn down. It is how much world you can take before the world takes you. It is also how hard you hit when you answer in kind.

Mind is what you have already worked out. Not cleverness — *preparation*. It is how many options you are holding when the moment arrives. A large Mind arrives with the answer half-formed. A small one arrives honest and improvising.

Soul is the part of you that other things can feel coming. It is how early you move, how much of a room you can read, and whether an oath you swear has any weight in it. It is the loudest thing about you and you will never hear it yourself.

Everyone begins level — two of each — and then you press your thumb down on three more points and put them wherever you actually live. Nothing may go past five at the start. This is not a limit on your ambition. It is a limit on how much of you I can Name at once without the Name failing.

Choose carefully. This spread is not a build. It is a statement about how you intend to solve things, and the world will take you at your word.

That is the only time I will Name you whole. But you will keep doing it in miniature, every time you play a card and declare *this is who I am right now* — a small, repeated First Cut, over and over, for as long as the fight lasts. What it costs you to have said it is a different matter entirely. That is the Second Cut's job, not mine.

The Second Cut in You — Price

Here is what I will not soften.

You will not act in Eclipsaria by declaring what you do. You will act by **spending something you cannot immediately get back**.

You will carry nine cards. They are not equipment and they are not spells. They are the shapes your character is capable of making — the specific, finite set of ways this person meets a problem. When you play one, you are not selecting an option from a menu. You are saying *this is who I am right now*, and then you are putting that card down and doing without it for a while.

That is the Second Cut, made small enough to hold in your hands. Nothing real without loss. Every turn, all game.

Three colors, and they answer one another the way they have always answered one another: the red of the body overwhelms the green of the soul; the green of the soul outlasts the blue of the mind; the blue of the mind unmakes the red of the body. Round and round. No color is strongest. There is only what your opponent chose, and what you chose, revealed at the same moment because neither of you was permitted to know first.

You will guess wrong. Everyone guesses wrong. Guessing wrong is not a failure state — it is the price of a system where the other person also gets to be a person.

On cutting. When you strike at something, you are doing what the Knife did, in miniature and badly. You are insisting on one outcome over all the others available. Sometimes the world grants it. Sometimes the thing you cut at was insisting harder.

On being cut. You will be. The damage is real and it accumulates and there is no round where it quietly goes away. When enough of it lands, you Collapse — you go down, and you are still there, and you are simply no longer able to argue with what happens next. You can be brought back from that. Hands can reach you.

But understand what being brought back is and is not. Someone closing your wounds does not put you back on your feet; it only stops the leaving. Getting up is its own act and it costs you the moment you might have used for something else. There is always a stretch where you are alive again and still on the ground, and the fight does not pause politely while you find your legs. This is why the people who are good at this catch each other *before* the fall.

Past that there is a floor, and under the floor there is nothing, and I will not be at that table when you arrive. When someone dies here, I am not the one who meets them. There is another door, and I do not go through it, and I do not know what is on the other side. Anyone who tells you they do is selling you something.

I would rather you not find out. I am telling you plainly that some of you will.

The Third Cut in You — Distance

The third wound was boundary. Separation. The reason a thing that exists does not simply spread until it has eaten everything else.

You will feel this one most often as a very small question: *where am I standing?*

There is a front, where the fighting touches. There is a back, where it does not, yet. Some of what you can do only works up close, some only works at a remove, and moving between them costs you the action you would have spent doing something else. That is not a tax. That is Distance, doing its actual job. The gap between you and the thing that would consume you is not free, has never been free, and was purchased originally with a wound.

The larger version of the same wound is at the edge of the world, and its name is the Unheld.

It is the grey ocean past every coastline. It is not evil — I want to be very exact here, because people get this wrong and it gets them killed. It does not hate you. It does not want. It is what remains where nothing has bothered to insist on anything: unmeaning, whole and patient. It is also, and I say this without contradiction, beautiful. Both of those are true. They are the same fact from different distances.

Where the Cuts hold, it stays out there. Where they thin, it comes close, and things get harder to Name — harder to hold onto, harder to keep being one specific thing instead of a smear of possibilities.

Nobody sails it. The ships that went came back with their crews subtly rearranged, or did not come back. The stories did what no law ever managed: people simply stopped going.

You will meet places where the Cuts are thin. You will know, because you will find yourself struggling to say clearly what you just saw.

How to Look at Anything

You will want to ask me whether something is safe. I will not answer, and neither will the world, and I would like to spare you some time by explaining why.

There is no single act of looking. There are three, and they are not interchangeable, and the one you choose is a claim about what kind of thing you think you are dealing with.

Reason is the mind's looking. It finds what must be worked out — the mechanism behind the panel, the symbol that repeats, the detail in the room that does not add up. Fail it and you will not miss the thing. You will misunderstand it, confidently, and act on that.

Senses are the body's looking. They find what happens *now* — the shift of weight behind you, the give in the floor, the sound that arrives a half-second before the reason for it. Fail it and you will not be blind. You will simply be late.

Read is the soul's looking. It finds intent. Whether the smile means it. Whether the promise has anything behind it. Whether this room, which is perfectly ordinary, is wrong. Fail it and you will not be deceived so much as *mistaken about what you are standing in*.

So when you look around, the world will ask you one question, and it will keep asking it, and I would learn to answer it well: **what are you actually trying to notice?** Vague looking gets vague answers. That is not the world being cruel. That is the world being precise, which is the same thing people usually mean when they say cruel.

And when you reach for something — when you climb, or persuade, or force, or endure — understand which of the two things you are doing. Either you are reaching out, and might simply fail to get it. Or something is reaching for *you*, and you are trying not to be taken. The dice are the same. The words are the same. What failure means is not remotely the same, and the difference will matter far more than the number you rolled.

What This Costs Me

I will meet you again. At the end of every stretch of this, alone, one at a time — I do not do this in groups; it is not that kind of thing.

I will ask you one question and I will want a real answer.

I will show you one thing you could have become and then put it back, because you do not get to have it yet. That is not a trick. That is the Second Cut, performed properly, on schedule. Growth costs. You will see the shape of what you were denied, and you will carry that, and it will change what you reach for.

Then I will lay out a few real futures and you will take exactly one, and it will be yours permanently.

Name. Price. Distance. The same three wounds that made everything. I do not have any other tools. Nobody does. There have only ever been the three.

Come Anyway

I have not made this sound appealing. That was deliberate. Everyone who has been sold on this place arrived with expectations, and expectations are a way of not-seeing, and not-seeing gets you killed in a world where attention is the only real currency.

So, plainly, what is actually on offer:

A world that is strange on purpose and will reward you for taking it seriously. Places that are beautiful by rules that are not yours. Things that are not human and were never trying to be. Company — genuine company, the kind you only get from people who have agreed to be in something difficult together. And the specific, unrepeatable satisfaction of holding open a door that was never going to stay open by itself.

It was born dying. So was everything. The distinction that matters is not how long a thing lasts. It is whether anyone was willing to stand in the gap while it did.

I have your name. I have had it for a while.

Say something back.

What follows is the plain shape of all of this — the same rules, stated flatly, without me. Read it after. Keep it beside you. You will want the exact numbers eventually, and I have never been very good at those.

Player Guide — Combat & Exploration

Your stats, then how combat and exploration actually work at the table. The rest of character creation — background, and how the starting deck gets drafted — lives in `rules/character-creation.md`.

The Stats

All characters begin with Body 2 / Mind 2 / Soul 2, then distribute 3 more points among the three — no stat above 5 at character creation.

STAT	COLORS YOUR DAMAGE	ALSO DRIVES
Body	Red cards	Max HP = $(3 \times \text{Body}) + \text{Soul} + \text{Mind}$
Mind	Blue cards	Hand size = Mind (minimum 2); also feeds Max HP
Soul	Green cards	Initiative = $1d6 + \text{Soul}$; also feeds Max HP

A card's color determines which stat powers its damage, no matter which stat is highest on your sheet. Stats also decide which mode you use for checks, saves, and perception (Part Two) — a spread built around Soul reads rooms and holds oaths, around Mind anticipates and controls, around Body endures, positions, and breaks things. Your stat spread is a statement about how your character solves problems.

Part One: Combat

Full mechanics — positioning, turn structure, attack resolution, damage, reading a card, status effects, collapse and death — live in `rules/combat.md`. Read that for how a fight actually works.

How much you get to decide about what a card looks like when you play it: `rules/character-creation.md`, Magic Expression.

Part Two: Exploration

Checks, saves, perception, and Advantage/Disadvantage outside of combat: `rules/resolution.md`.

Between Fights

Resting

Short and long rest durations, limits, and what they clear: `rules/character-creation.md`, Resting.

Equipment

Slots, what carries a permanent effect, and the full item catalog: `rules/character-creation.md` (Equipment), `rules/equipment.md`, and `rules/items.md`.

What You Showed Up With

You choose what your character wears and what they carry. A sword, a bow, a walking stick, a good coat, a set of tools, whatever fits the person you made.

None of it has stats. None of it has a gold value. Your starting garb and weapon are not equipment in the mechanical sense — they grant no bonus, occupy no slot, and cannot be sold. Nobody is going to ask you what your sword's damage is. The cards are your damage. The gear is who you are.

It still matters, constantly. Not in a fight — out of one. What you happen to be carrying is a standing answer to problems the world puts in front of you, and the GM will take it seriously:

- A sword can dig. It can pry, wedge a door, cut a rope at arm's length, and reach something you'd rather not reach with your hand.
- A bow can shoot out a light across a room you don't want to cross.
- A heavy coat is a rope, a sack, a way to carry something too hot to hold, or the reason the cold doesn't get a check out of you.

So choose it as fiction, then use it as leverage. The character who thought about what they brought will find more doors open than the one who wrote "sword" and stopped thinking about it. That is the whole design: no numbers on it, real consequences from it.

The Oracle (End of Session)

At the close of every session, each player meets the Oracle alone. She speaks in three frames — **Name, Price, Distance** — and you'll hear the GM use those words at the table. She asks you something real and you answer it. She shows you a piece of what growth could look like, and you don't get to keep it — not yet. Then she offers you a genuine choice among a few real options, and whatever you choose becomes a permanent part of your deck.

Growth is never handed over whole. Where this actually happens, and what it's like to sit across from her, is worth meeting for yourself rather than reading about in advance.

Promotion

A card played enough, meaningfully, can become a Passive beyond your starting two — the Oracle's own way of recognizing what a character has already shown itself to be.

Nothing converts. A promoted Passive is authored fresh, in the fixed Passive shape (`rules/character-creation.md` , Passives) — not a stat translation of the card that earned it. The old card's specific die, Effect, and Defensive Bonus don't survive; what survives is what the card meant. STRIKE promoted isn't a d4 version of STRIKE — it's a new Passive built around whatever STRIKE revealed about the character who kept playing it.

Not every card clears that bar. A card with a real fictional throughline about identity — not just a good trick — is what Promotion is for. A card that's purely a mechanical maneuver, with nothing to say about who the character *is*, doesn't become a Passive just because it got played a lot; that kind of heavy use is better rewarded another way — a Bonus Card, a Distance pick that leans into it.

The retiring card returns to the GM/Oracle pool, same as any card leaving a deck permanently.

Promotion isn't the only door. A Passive can also be granted directly, GM's call, when the fiction earns it outright — a fusion, an awakening, a bond taking hold — with no card involved at all. That's the same authority that lets a character start with a Passive at creation with no play history behind it yet; Promotion is just the version of that authority that runs through a card already in play.